

Line Changeover Between Product Categories

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Why changeover time is protected capacity

A line switching from one product category to another loses productive hours to machine reconfiguration, needle and thread changes, attachment swaps and a re-balanced operator layout. This lost time is not idle time and must be subtracted from available capacity before a feasibility answer is given.

Standard changeover durations

From	To	Duration	Notes
Knit to knit (polo to t-shirt)		3 hours	Needle and thread change only
Knit to woven (polo to formal shirt)		1.5 shifts	Full attachment and folder change
Woven to knit		1 shift	Attachments removed, overlock reset
Any category to fleece or hoodie		1 shift	Heavier needles, feed adjustment
Denim to any lighter fabric		1.5 shifts	Deep clean required for indigo migration

One shift is eight productive hours. LINE-001 and LINE-002 run knits, LINE-003 runs woven formal shirts and denim, and LINE-004 runs fleece and heavier constructions. Moving a style off its home line always incurs a changeover.

Changeover and reallocation decisions

When a shortfall is covered by moving volume to another line, the changeover cost is charged to the receiving line, not the originating one. A reallocation that saves two days of capacity but costs 1.5 shifts of changeover is only worthwhile above roughly 1,500 units.

Below that threshold, overtime on the home line is the cheaper option and should be proposed instead.

Approval

Any changeover longer than one shift requires production manager approval because it consumes capacity already committed to another order. The agent may propose the move but must not treat the capacity as released until the approval is recorded.